



The god Pazuzu, who as "king of the evil spirits" can ward off disease, looks down from the top of the amulet.

The "heavenly domain" shows the symbols of the highest gods, such as the star of the goddess Ishtar.

Priests dressed in fish skins perform exorcism rituals at the bedside of the patient, probably a mother who has given birth. The lamp on the left indicates that this happens at night.

Pazuzu, who has a dog's head, a scorpion's tail, and bird talons, chases the malevolent Lamashu back to the netherworld.

Lamashu, the demonic goddess who preys on pregnant women and babies, has the naked torso of an old woman—with a pig and a dog drinking from her breasts. She carries a poisonous snake in each hand.

Purging demons
The Mesopotamians had a complex belief system of supernatural beings and forces. This Assyrian bronze amulet highlights the importance of these beliefs in explaining and treating disease.

CHASTEBERRY
(MENSTRUAL PROBLEMS)

ROSEHIP
(SOOTHING TONIC)

GINSENG
(STIMULANT)

Medicinal plants
The health-giving or healing properties of many roots, seeds, and leaves have been recognized since ancient times and confirmed by modern medical science.

HOW WE KNOW

SKELETAL HEALTH

Many of the ancient ideas about health and disease can be gleaned from the art, writing, and artifacts of the time. But equally important are human remains, such as bones, teeth, and other tissues. Skeletal remains are the most valuable, because they decay very slowly. They often show physical signs of deformity or malnutrition, and can also provide a physical record of certain medical interventions, including primitive surgery. Further details can be revealed under the microscope and by carrying out tests. Analysis of the chemical isotopes present and examination of the DNA can reveal subtle clues to what a person ate, how old they were, and how they lived and died.

HEALED BONE FRACTURE, ANCIENT EGYPT

AFTER

During the 1st millennium BCE, medicine became more systematic, but supernatural explanations and nonscientific folk remedies prevailed until after the scientific revolution of the 18th century.

ACUPUNCTURE

Acupuncture aims to restore health and well-being, and to relieve pain. Still one of the mainstays of Chinese medicine, it was probably developed in **Han China 128–29** around 200 CE—although there is some evidence that it was used earlier. The locations



ACUPUNCTURE POINTS

of tattoos on a well-preserved body, nicknamed Ötzi after its discovery, tally very closely with important acupuncture points. Ötzi's body was discovered in 1991, in the Alps between Italy and Austria—he lived about 3350 BCE

INDIAN PROGRESS

The Ayurveda system flourished across the Indian subcontinent. Its main exponent was **Sushruta**, whose 6th-century BCE work *Sushruta Samhita* describes more than 100 surgical instruments and 300 surgical procedures. Many historians of medicine refer to him as the "Father of Surgery."

ANCIENT GREEK MEDICINE

The thinkers of ancient Greece 104–05, 130–131 were among the first to apply careful observation and rational thought to philosophical questions, and this extended to medicine. Medical practice was dominated by the theory of "humors." According to this, the human body was composed of **four humors**: blood, phlegm, black bile, and yellow bile, and illness was the result of an imbalance between them.

Although much of ancient Greek medicine was derived in isolation, Greek thinkers were influenced by Egyptian medicine, which had many excellent herbal remedies.



GALEN DISSECTING

ROMAN MEDICINE

Doctors in ancient Rome followed Greek medical practices, but while the Greeks had used philosophy to explain disease, the Romans reverted to explanations that depended on the whims of the gods. The greatest Roman physician and anatomist was **Claudius Galenus (Galen)**, who lived in the 2nd century CE. His ideas about anatomy were based on careful observation, but many were false. Nevertheless, they dominated Western medicine until the 16th century. Ancient Rome

is celebrated for its initiatives on public health. Their water supplies, sewage and heating systems, and public baths were well ahead of their time.